

[SAB]+[SSAATB]

Commissioned By:

The Philharmonic Chorus
of Madison
in 2025



Jon D. Nelson

Flashlights in the Dark

An electro-acoustic score for 54-piece concert choir,
28 smartphones, computer, & closed-network

3rd Edition

Original Twin-Text By:

Clare Malinowski, Jon Nelson & Seama Rezai

Set in the year of 2076

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Flashlights in the Dark

Original Twin-Poem by Clare Malinowski, Jon Nelson, and Seama Rezai

Set in 2076

Shadow Chorus

Here now, awake with no light,
who sees beyond this dark night?
This world is loud; what binds us now, soul?
Oh, what hollow faith is near;
remember when voices rang?
Look at this! This fragile world;
yet love shines through in the night.
Our eyes fail; alas, in time we feel less and less

Who can feel?
Who feels these withered trees?
New rains fall on dreary dawns;
where is the sun to dry our new day?
What are wonders in night?
Where are wonders without stars?

Where sleeps the light?
Deep shadows live in night.
We carry on with flashlights in darkness;
we must embrace this new world,
our one world,
this brave world.

Warm breath, warm hands,
together we stand.
Should your hands grow weary,
we'll carry yours too.

One light, though dim,
with love, can pierce night.
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
Where are we, in the night,
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
our new home?

night, light,
light, night,
night, light,
light night,
light.

Light Chorus

Here now, awake with no light,
who sees beyond this dark night?
Who sees life, light,
we are connected by life, seeking the light.
Arise! Here! Look at this! A creation age!
They will build as we design; we can fine'ly imagine now!
What a world! Tides will start to turn.
In the night, at last, we rest.

Here, look here;
look at this! new light!
Shining, singing, this will bloom.
In night we bloom as autumn,
with color preceding night,
flurries of color in the sky!

Where sleeps the light?
Deep shadows live in night.
We'll carry ours, here, in darkness,
so here: embrace this new world,
our bright world,
this bright, shared world.

Should your hands grow weary,
I'll carry your light.

One light, though dim,
with love, can pierce night.
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
Where are we, in the night,
Who are we; warm hearts, light?
our new home?

In the night,
bring light.
In the night,
we bring light,
hmm.

Set in a dystopian world of 2076, "Flashlights in the Dark" brings two opposing choruses, each shaped by their differing experiences, into one shared space. A "Light" chorus looks toward possibility and renewal, while a "Shadow" chorus laments danger, loss, and unrest; neither perspective is wholly right nor wrong. As their twin texts collide, answer, and gradually begin to listen, the music moves toward warmth and solidarity, not by erasing disagreement, but by discovering how to stand together within it.

Technology itself is an active participant in this drama. Networked smartphones each provide individual torches in a coordinated field of musically responsive lights, while electro-acoustic sounds prime, answer, and extend the choir's live singing. In the end, human voices, electronic sound, and timed lights ultimately converge in a shared message: even in darkness, unity can be created through attention, care, and the light we are willing to carry for one another in times of need.

[Duration: 8 minutes]

Set in 2076

Flashlights in the Dark

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Begin in darkness
Moderato (♩ = c. 102)

*Sounds of
flowing water*

2

*nighttime sounds mixed with
cacophonous shimmering jingling*

Score for the first system (Measures 1-10). The music is in 4/4 time and features a Shadow Chorus (Soprano, Alto, Baritone) and a Light Chorus (Soprano L1, L2; Alto L1, L2; Tenor/Bass L). The lyrics are:

Shadow Chorus:
Soprano S: no light dark night
Alto S: Here now a-wake with no light this dark night
Baritone S: Here now a-wake with no light Who sees be-yond this dark night

Light Chorus:
Soprano L1, L2: no light dark
Alto L1, L2: Here now a-wake with no light dark
Tenor/Bass L: Here now a-wake with no light who sees be-yond? dark

Score for the second system (Measures 11-18). The music is in 4/4 time and features a Shadow Chorus (Soprano, Alto, Baritone) and a Light Chorus (Soprano L1, L2; Alto L1, L2; Tenor/Bass L). The lyrics are:

Shadow Chorus:
S S: This world is loud; what binds us now? Soul?
A S: This world is loud; what binds us now? Oh, what hol - low faith is near?
Bar S: This world is loud; what binds us now? Oh, what hol - low faith is near? Here, here

Light Chorus:
S L1, L2: we are con-nec-ted by life seeking the light A-rise! Here! Lookat this! Acre-a - tionage!
A L1, L2: we are con-nec-ted by life seeking the light Arise! Here! Lookat this! A cre-a - tionage!
T/B L: we are con-nec-ted by life seeking the light A rise! Here, here! Look at this! Acre-a - tionage!

14 *swell of robot sounds* *rocket sounds* **19** *mp*

Shadow S S look at this! this fra-gile world Yet lo ve shines through though

Shadow A S look at this! this fra-gile world Yet lo ve shines

Bar S re-member when voi-ces rang? look at this! this fra-gile world Yet lo ve shines through

S L1, L2 They will build as we design! look at this! what a world! tides will start to turn

Light A L1, L2 They will build as we design! we can fin'ly i-magine now what a world! tides will start to turn

T/B L They will build as we design! we can fin'ly i-magine now oh what a world! tides will start to turn

26 *clock ticking sounds* *Andante* ♩ = 72

Shadow S S in the night our eyes fail a las in time we feel less and less

Shadow A S in the night our eyes fail a las in time we feel less and less

Bar S in the night our eyes fail a las in time we feel less and less

S L1, L2

Light A L1, L2 *mp* *> pp* *p* *mp* *pp* in the night at last we rest

T/B L *pp* *mp* *> pp* *p* *mp* *pp* In night, at last we rest

31

31

p Who can feel? *mp* Who feels these with-ered trees?

p Who can feel? *mp* Who feels these with-ered trees?

p Who can feel? *mp* Who feels these with-ered trees?

mf Here, look here, look at this! new light

mf Here, look here, look at this! new light

mf Here, look here, look at this! new new light

38

38

pp *mf* where is the sun

pp *mf* *mp* new rains fall on dreary dawns where is the sun to dry our new day

pp *mf* *mp* new rains fall on dreary dawns where is the sun sun to dry our new day

mp in the night we bloom as

mp Shin-ing in night we bloom as au-tumn Here

mp Shin-ing in night tumn Here

mp Shin-ing, sing-ing, this will bloom, as au-tumn

in night we bloom as au-tumn tumn Here

48

62 **66**

Shadow

S S
live in night We car - ry on with flash - lights we car - ry on in this

A S
live in night We car - ry on with flash lights in dark ness em-brace

Bar S
live in night so - we must em-brace this

Light

S L1, L2
- - - We car - ry on with flash - lights - we car - ry on in dark ness behold

A L1, L2
- - - We'll car - ry ours here in dark ness - dark ness behold

T/B L
lean on night We'll car - ry ours here in dark ness so here be-hold this

71 **80**

Shadow

S S
new world, our one world, this brave world

A S
new world, our one world, this brave world

Bar S
new world, our one world, this brave world

Light

S L1, L2
- new -world, - bright world, - bright shared world -

A L1, L2
- new -world - bright world, - bright shared world -

T/B L
new world, bright world, bright shared world

musique concrète

89

Shadow

S S

8 *p*

warm hands, warm breath here we stand as

A S

8 *p*

warm hands, warm breath, here we stand as

Bar S

8 *p*

warm hands, warm breath, here here we stand

Light

S L1, L2

8

A L1, L2

8

T/B L

8

98

C maj9/E

Shadow

S S

97

one

car - ry yours too

A S

one

car - ry yours too

Bar S

here we stand

yours too

Light

S L1, L2

hands, grow wear - ry

Should your hands-grow weary- I'll car - ry yours too

A L1, L2

(E = Fb)

p

wear - ry I'll car - ry your light too

ff

hands grow weary I'll car - ry yours too

p

wear - ry I'll car - ry your light

ff

(yours too)

T/B L

here should your hands grow wear - ry I'll car - ry your light too

104

E♭/B♭

 D^-/F

D-(sus4)(sus9)

 D^-/A
$$Bb(\text{add2}) \quad F^- \quad 11$$
D $\flat$ Lydian/F

CMaj 9/E

$$C^{-\Delta/Eb}$$
[illegible]

114

114 *pp* *rearticulate freely in aleatoric style*

S S Who? who who who who

Shadow A S *pp* *rearticulate freely in aleatoric style* Who? who who who who

Bar S *p* who are we; warm hearts light? Where are we, the night,

S L1, L2 *p* who are we; warm hearts light? Where are we, in the night,

Light A L1, L2 *p* who are we; warm hearts light? Where are we, in the night,

T/B L *p* who are we; warm hearts light? Where are we, in the night,

122

rearticulate freely in aleatoric style

S S who — who who who — who — Who? — who — who — who

Shadow A S who — who who who — who — Who? — who — who — who

Bar S who are we; Who are we? Warm hearts light Who? — who — who — who

S L1, L2 Who are we? one light Who are we —

Light A L1, L2 who are we; Who are we? Warm hearts light Who are we? one light Who are we —

T/B L who are we; Who are we? Warm hearts light Who are we? one light Who are we —

134

shimmering polytonal sound chandelier

S S light — light night — night — light — light — night light

Shadow A S light — light night — night — light — light — night light

Bar S light — light night — night — light — light — night light

S L1, L2 *pp* here, our new home? in night we bring light in night light in the night we bring light hmm — *mp* *ppp*

Light A L1, L2 *pp* here, our new home? in night we bring light in night light in the night we bring light hmm — *mp* *ppp*

T/B L *pp* here, our new home? in — night — in — night — bring — light hmm —

PERFORMER RESOURCES

Electronics, rehearsal support, and permanent links

PERMANENT ONLINE HOME

simphoni.ai/flashlights

This is the permanent home for Flashlights in the Dark and the public starting point for its ever-evolving singer resources. The short address keex.ai/flashlights opens the same hub.

THE ELECTRONICS, IN BRIEF

Flashlights in the Dark is an electro-acoustic work for choir, assigned singer smartphones, and a Mac-based conductor console. During performance, all devices join a dedicated, closed Wi-Fi network. The console sends low-latency OSC cues that route synchronized audio and flashlight sequences to each singer's assigned device. Internet access is not part of the live control path.

LEARNING THE PIECE

The hub provides part-by-part practice audio, mixer controls, score and production materials, setup help, and current rehearsal notes. The client also includes Trigger Practice for previewing the audio and lighting assigned to your seat. Use headphones for individual audio practice.

LIGHTING ADVISORY Bright, rapidly changing phone-light sequences are used. Follow production and venue accessibility guidance.

BEFORE REHEARSAL OR PERFORMANCE

- Install or update the current client before rehearsal.
- Fully charge the device and bring its charging cable.
- Allow Camera and Local Network access. No microphone or Bluetooth pairing is needed.
- Join the production Wi-Fi, select your assigned seat or slot, and keep the app open in the foreground.
- Production verifies every device before cues are armed.

ABOUT THE COMPOSER

Jon D. Nelson is a composer, pianist, creative technologist, and educator whose work connects contemporary classical composition with networked performance, electronics, recording, and spatial media. He earned composition degrees from the Royal College of Music and Ball State University and is Founder & Creative Technologist for KEEEx.AI / Simphoni, developing human-directed creative technologies centered on artistic judgment and agency.

jondnelson.com *Portfolio and biography*

SCAN FROM THIS PRINTED SCORE

The permanent KEEEx addresses printed below can be retargeted without changing the score.

RESOURCE HUB



keex.ai/flashlights

Practice media + updates

iPHONE / iPAD



keex.ai/flashlights/ios

Install or update

ANDROID



keex.ai/flashlights/android

Install or update